
DALE NIRVANI PFEIFER

Chapter 1, on the house.

Why Judgment Is Becoming the Differentiator. The opening chapter of **Artificial Intelligence for Nonprofit Fundraising**, free to read in one sitting.

AI did not change fundraising because it made tasks faster. It changed fundraising because it changed where judgment lives.

FROM THE CONCLUSION

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FORMAT

Chapter 1 preview

INSIDE THIS PREVIEW

Twelve pages. One argument.

Chapter 1 makes the case the rest of the book is built on: the question has moved from whether nonprofits should adopt AI to which decisions they are willing to let it shape. It is short, practical, and written to be read in one sitting.

76%

of nonprofits report using AI in some form

9%

feel ready to use it responsibly

15%

have any AI governance or policy in place

AI Equity Project 2025, surveying 850 nonprofits across the United States and Canada.

What you get in these pages

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- 01** A working example: how one solo development director flagged 312 at-risk donors and interrupted the lapse before it happened.
 - 02** Three workflow shifts that compress data, insight, and action into a single decision loop.
 - 03** Why readiness is an organizational discipline, not something individual fundraisers should be asked to solve alone.
 - 04** Five takeaways you can bring to a leadership or board conversation this week.
 - 05** One Take Action exercise to run with your team before you adopt any new AI tool.
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Why Judgment Is Becoming the Differentiator

AI can help even rebalance the philanthropic ecosystem so the field isn't dominated by the most prominent, wealthiest nonprofits.

Jeff Raikes, Co-founder of the Raikes Foundation, and Dale Nirvani Pfeifer, "Reducing AI bias: A path forward"

Jordan's Story (Part 1)

A few weeks later, Jordan stepped out of the Denver conference hall with a racing pulse. She had gone to a conference to meet that solo development director and he had demonstrated a system that predicted which existing donors were most likely to lapse.

He had exported twelve months of donor data and the model flagged 312 at-risk donors and generated a personalized re-engagement email sequence. Before anything went out, he reviewed and edited each message to make sure it sounded like him (not his AI). The sequence included a short personalized email series, a targeted invitation to an upcoming program event, and a few well-placed impact metrics tied directly to the programs each specific donor had supported.

Within two weeks, open rates were up, responses were coming in, and donations were continuing. Early signs of disengagement had been interrupted. What struck Jordan most was not the sophistication of the technology but how accessible it was. What once required a data scientist and a team of interns had been prototyped by one person in an afternoon.

If a small, under-resourced nonprofit could move this quickly, Jordan knew her mid-sized nonprofit no longer had the luxury of waiting.

A Structural Shift in Fundraising

Jordan's story captures more than a clever use of AI. It signals a structural shift in fundraising. Today, lean teams with limited budgets can use AI to identify risk earlier, personalize outreach at scale, and make smarter decisions about where to focus scarce time and attention.

This shift presents both a significant opportunity and a clear wakeup call.

Readiness is organizational, not individual

Fundraisers operate in trust-based environments, steward sensitive donor data, and serve communities where mistakes carry real human and reputational consequences. If AI personalization is done poorly, it can erode donor confidence faster than it is being built. In the absence of clear guidance and training, caution is not inertia; it is professional and ethical judgment.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

While AI adoption is accelerating, only 9 percent of nonprofits feel ready to use AI responsibly. That disconnect tells us something important: AI is here, but organizations often lack the governance, training, and safeguards required for ethical and effective use.

This reframes readiness as a shared responsibility. Fundraisers are often the first to see both the opportunity and the risk of AI in practice. Readiness is not about asking staff to use AI more but about supporting that work by providing clear guardrails, strengthening core data systems and data quality, defining acceptable use, and creating space for learning without fear of reputational risk.

Three Workflow Shifts Redefining Fundraising Decisions

Rather than treating AI as a collection of features or platforms, this book focuses on how it reshapes the way fundraisers move from data to decisions to action. I have observed three major shifts across the sector.

1. Data to Insight, in minutes

Pattern-recognition models can identify donors who might stop giving or could upgrade. Insights that once took weeks of spreadsheet wrangling now show up in minutes. This only works when the underlying data is clean, current, and consistently maintained. Without that foundation, faster access just surfaces errors more efficiently.

2. Insight to Action, at scale

Once a donor has been flagged for risk, upgrade, or reactivation, the next step isn't someone manually drafting emails or sorting lists. AI-connected tools can create message drafts, queue the outreach, and suggest the best channel based on past behavior. These are drafts only. Team members review each one for tone and accuracy.

3. Action to System to Strategy loops

Every campaign has feedback loops, opens, responses, gifts, drop-offs, that retrain models and improve recommendations. Teams stop reacting to lagging indicators and start steering with forward-looking signals such as propensity scores and projected lifetime value.

Key takeaways

AI isn't just a new tool. It changes how you work.

Most fundraising workflows have the same shape: find information, make sense of it, then act. AI compresses all three steps into one.

Speed without trust is risk.

AI can enable faster, more personalized outreach, but only if it is used in conjunction with human judgment, transparency, and clear oversight.

Fundraisers become stewards, not operators.

When AI handles the manual work, your team can focus on what donors actually value: good judgment, right timing, and real relationships.

Readiness is organizational, not individual.

Successful adoption depends on shared guardrails, data discipline, and leadership support. Not asking fundraisers to figure it out on their own.

Strategic advantage compounds over time.

Every campaign makes the next one smarter by connecting insight, action, and learning. Fundraising goes from reactive to predictive.

At this point, AI moves from being a helpful feature to a strategic lens, shaping how priorities are set, resources are allocated, and donor relationships are stewarded over time.

Take action

BEFORE YOU CHOOSE ANY TOOLS

Stop and sync with your team before you select tools.

- Name one part of your fundraising workflow that currently relies on instinct or lagging data, for example who to re-engage or when to follow up.
- Identify the points in a decision where judgment must remain human, to protect donor trust, tone, and values.
- Document one guardrail your nonprofit would need in place before applying AI to that decision, such as human review, consent clarity, or data limits.

This reflection sets the foundation for responsible experimentation and prevents speed from outpacing trust.

A NOTE ON WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

When I started writing, the nonprofit sector was already under strain. By the time it goes to print, that strain has deepened. Federal funding reductions, shifting funder priorities, and declining donor participation are compressing budgets and burning out the people doing this work. I wrote this book because I was worried, and because I wanted to do something useful. AI will not solve a funding crisis. But for fundraisers and small teams carrying impossible workloads, it can return enough time and focus to keep going. That is what this book is for.

Dale

KEEP READING

The rest of the book picks up here.

Fifteen chapters and twelve named case studies, each pairing a working framework with an organization that tested it. Real teams, specific results, and the vendor stack they used.

Get the book

Artificial Intelligence for Nonprofit Fundraising is available now on Amazon in print and Kindle.

The Dispatch

One thoughtful note a month on AI and philanthropy. No pitch, no filler.

For your team

Half and full-day workshops, six-week AI Fundraising Sprints, and monthly coaching. Grounded in the fundraising P&L, not generic AI literacy.

For funders

Cohort programs that take 20 to 50 grantees through the Sprint together, so a portfolio builds capability at once.

Free AI policy template

A one-page nonprofit AI use policy you can adapt and put in front of your board.

aifundraisingfornonprofits.com

Dale Nirvani Pfeifer is the author of Artificial Intelligence for Nonprofit Fundraising and speaks to nonprofit audiences on AI and the future of giving. She has spoken at TEDx, the United Nations, SXSW, and Money 20/20.